

Under-19 stage to launch memorable international careers in the last decade. However, despite the glut of talent in the age-group system, the successful transition to the highest level has stalled in recent years.

Since the 2020 U-19 World Cup, which launched Jaiswal and included Tilak Varma, Ravi Bishnoi and Dhruv Jurel, no Indian from the following two editions (2022 and 2024) has made it to the national team. The 2022 title-winning squad, led by Yash Dhull, and Uday Saharan's 2024 batch have yet to get their big break, despite prospects like Raj Bawa, Shaikh Rasheed and Musheer Khan whetting the appetite for a future star.

However, Ayush Mhatre's class of 2026 could end that drought, with 14-year-old Vaibhav Suryavanshi, the youngest of the lot, a prime contender to graduate to the senior team. The swashbuckling left-hander has made power-hitting look like child's play since his first taste of the Indian Premier League (IPL) last year, during which he cracked a 35-ball century that sent a slew of records tumbling.

Suryavanshi has used the Under-19 stage as a recreational playground, smashing two centuries in fewer than 60 deliveries over the past year. During India's recent 3-0 series sweep against South Africa, he notched up the fastest Youth ODI fifty, off just 15 balls, to break Pant's record. That Suryavanshi did not curb his instincts even during a high-stakes U-19 Asia Cup final against Pakistan, where he struck a 10-ball 26 in a losing cause, typifies his unrelenting faith in a high-tempo approach. A prolific World Cup campaign could be his ticket to a potential India call-up.

Mumbai's Mhatre (right), who has cemented his spot across formats on the domestic circuit, has also been earmarked as a future India prospect, particularly following his breakout IPL 2025 campaign with Chennai Super Kings as a mid-season replacement. Though consistency has eluded Mhatre in age-group cricket, he has underlined

his leadership credentials on India's successful tours of England and Australia, and during a run to the final of the Under-19 Asia Cup.

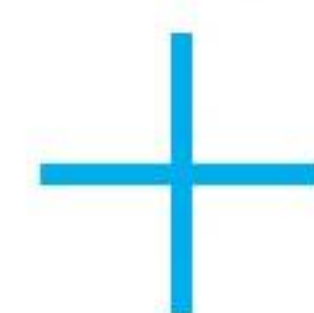
The continental event in the UAE also shot wicketkeeper-batter Abhigyan Kundu to fame, as the 17-year-old became the first Indian to register a double century in Youth ODIs during a contest against Malaysia. The left-hander finished as the tournament's second-highest run-getter, with 276 runs in four innings at a blistering strike rate of 142.26. Vice-captain Vihaan Malhotra, picked by Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) in the recently held IPL auction, has also emerged as a reliable middle-order mainstay.

Aaron George, who led Hyderabad to the Vinoo Mankad Trophy title this season, has married consistency with flair at No. 3, averaging 61.83 while striking at over 100 in seven games in this World Cup cycle.

While batters have largely made a successful transition to the senior team from the Under-19 level, the ride has been bumpy for pacers in recent years. Kamlesh Nagarkoti, Shivam Mavi, Akash Singh and Kartik Tyagi shone brightly but briefly, their promise evaporating amid a slew of injuries. Tamil Nadu's Deepesh Devendran, who can hurry batters with decent pace and accurate bouncers, will hope to snap that dispiriting trend. Among the all-rounders, R.S. Ambrish, who has already made it to the Ranji Trophy, and Kanish Chouhan, picked by RCB for his handy off-spin and lower-order batting prowess, will be on the radar.

Grouped with Bangladesh, New Zealand and the USA, a well-rounded India is expected to storm into the Super Six stage, where sterner tests await, including an opportunity to avenge the Asia Cup final defeat to Pakistan.

But with a transition looming for the senior Indian team across formats, there will be more than fleeting rivalries at stake.



The squad

Ayush Mhatre (captain), Vihaan Malhotra (vice-captain), Vaibhav Suryavanshi, Aaron George, Vedant Trivedi, Abhigyan Kundu (wicket-keeper), Harvansh Singh (wicket-keeper), R.S. Ambrish, Kanishk Chouhan, Khilan A. Patel, Mohamed Enaan, Henil Patel, D. Deepesh, Kishan Kumar Singh, Udhav Mohan.



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